

diplomacy

PM'S CHINA VISIT

While trade will get a boost, the real challenge will be to make substantive progress on the vexatious border dispute

■ By Saurabh Shukla

As Prime Minister Manmohan Singh and members of his delegation climb the steps of the Great Hall of People, in the sub-zero temperature of Beijing on January 14, for talks with Chinese Premier Wen Jiabao, the two giants would seek to turn the page on major issues such as the border dispute, that continues to be an impediment in bilateral ties.

A day earlier, on Lohri, the Chinese premier will seek to disarm Manmohan with a blend of Chinese gastronomic delights at a private dinner in Beijing, which is expected to set the tone of the two-and-a-half-day visit. It is not expected to be a big headline visit, although this is the first by an Indian prime minister, in six years. During Atal Bihari Vajpayee's 2002 visit, India had got recognition of Sikkim in return for concessions on Tibet but this time the focus is on setting the bilateral agenda for 2008 and on strengthening cooperation on trade and global issues.

The prime minister's visit comes in the shadow of aggressive Chinese intrusions and patrolling on the border with close to 140 incursions reported last year. Besides, the ramp-up of Chinese strategic assets like roads, airports, railheads close to the line of actual control has made Delhi worry. While Manmohan is expected to flag India's concerns on the border issue, special representatives—National Security Advisor M.K. Narayanan and Dai Bingguo—are scheduled to meet but a breakthrough is unlikely. "The process of resolving this issue is on...it is a complicated matter," Manmohan remarked ahead of the visit.

The two countries had agreed on guiding principles and parameters to resolve the boundary dispute in April 2005 and have held 11 rounds of talks, without much success. Delhi maintains that China claims approximately 90,000 sq km of Indian territory in Arunachal Pradesh besides, about 38,000 sq km in J&K. Though Beijing is seeking major concessions in

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Arunachal Pradesh, its aggressive posture seems to indicate that it wants to strengthen its claim on the boundary question. India on its part, has effectively kept the Tibet issue on the backburner, and is unlikely to raise the pitch lest it irk China. While publically both sides want to settle the border issue, progress has been stalled on the question of major territorial concessions.

Unlike the past prime ministerial visits to China, this trip is less euphoric. In fact unlike his predecessor Vajpayee, Manmohan has even done away with a Chinese protocol—an interview to Chinese television. Instead, only a written interview will be put out. South Block is keen not to raise expectations and is not looking forward to many dramatic outcomes. Skeptics believe the visit would be more ritualistic in nature. "It is a visit without a clear purpose and continues the policy of having symbolism over substance," says strategic analyst Brahma Chellaney.

Trade is expected to be the big driver of the visit. With bilateral trade crossing \$37 billion (Rs 1,48,000 crore), the focus will be on expanding commerce. More than 40 Indian business leaders will be part of the official delegation. India would stress on correcting the huge trade imbalance that currently stands in favour of China. Delhi will also seek entry for its fruits and vegetables in the Chinese market. Since more than 40 per cent of bilateral trade is in iron ore, both would want to diversify. "The Indian industry is looking forward to greater engagement with China and this visit will help forge a strategic partnership," says Sunil Mittal, president, CN, who is leading the business delegation.

The big step of the visit will be greater coordination on key international issues. "We may have cooperation on some issues and confrontation on others but the underlying theme will be that India and China will work to-